

1. Vocation

Vocation names what the community believes it has been called to be. For an ecumenical community, this should probably focus on unity, reconciliation, prayer, shared life, and common witness rather than total doctrinal uniformity.

This answers: Why do we exist? What call are we responding to?

Example:

Our vocation is to seek the visible unity of Christ's Church through prayer, friendship, reconciliation, and shared witness.

2. Charism

Charism names the particular gift or grace the community has received for the sake of the Church and the world. It is more specific than "mission" and deeper than "values"; it describes the spiritual gift that gives the community its distinctive shape.

This answers: What particular gift has God entrusted to this community?

Example:

Our charism is reconciled friendship across Christian difference: a way of life in which Christians from different traditions receive one another, pray together, and serve together without erasing their distinct identities.

3. Rule of Life

Rule of Life describes the essential pattern that makes common life possible. It is where your commitments and corresponding practices belong together: not as abstract beliefs on one side and activities on the other, but as an integrated way of life.

This answers: How do we live the vocation and charism in concrete, repeatable ways?

Example categories inside a Rule of Life:

1. Prayer
2. Hospitality
3. Reconciliation
4. Shared discernment
5. Service
6. Simplicity
7. Formation
8. Ecumenical friendship

A Rule of Life might say: because we are called to unity, we pray together; because we are called to reconciliation, we practice confession and repair; because we are called to hospitality, we share meals and welcome strangers.

4. Common Life

Common Life describes the actual rhythms and shape of participation. If the Rule is the deep grammar, Common Life is what people experience when they show up: gatherings, meals, prayer services, retreats, formation groups, neighborhood presence, and works of mercy.

This answers: What does this community actually do together?

Example:

Our common life is shaped by weekly prayer, monthly shared meals, seasonal retreats, works of service, and ongoing formation in the spirituality of Christian unity.

5. Mission

Mission describes how the community's life is offered outwardly for the Church and the world. This is not merely "programs"; it is the outward movement of the community's vocation and charism.

This answers: For whom is this common life offered? Where is it sent?

Example:

Our mission is to make Christian unity visible through shared prayer, works of mercy, reconciliation across difference, and common witness in our city.

6. Constitutions

Constitutions describe the formal ordering of the community. They are not the same thing as the Rule of Life: the Rule describes the spiritual pattern; the Constitutions describe membership, leadership, decision-making, accountability, formation processes, finances, safeguarding, and how the community revises its commitments.

This answers: How is the community structured, governed, protected, and held accountable?

Example contents:

1. Membership and belonging
2. Leadership and offices
3. Decision-making
4. Accountability and discipline
5. Formation and discernment
6. Financial stewardship
7. Safeguarding policies
8. Amendment process
9. Relationship to churches or ecclesial authorities